THE CAREGIVER'S SECRET

Written by

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FADE IN:

INT. MAGNOLIA COURT ASSISTED LIVING - HALLWAY - NIGHT

A long hall, fluorescent and unforgiving. The station clock reads 1:52. A wheelchair sits at the far end like something nobody came back for.

MR. PELLEY (70s) sits upright in it, hands folded, patient the way people get when asking stopped working. A cold dinner tray rests on a side table, six inches past his fingertips.

DANA REYES (34), Latina, scrubs creased from sixteen hours, pushes a med cart past him. Stops.

At the nurses' station, a chart on a clipboard. Three entries, three handwritings. Refused meal. Refused meal. Refused meal.

Dana looks at the chart. At the tray. At his hands.

She slides the tray in front of him. Peels the foil off the plate. Folds his fingers around a fork.

MR. PELLEY
(hoarse)
Thank you.

DANA
Nobody's timing you.

He eats. The fork shakes. He lands it.

GAIL KESSLER (50s, lanyard, pen held like a baton) leans out of the station with a sheet.

GAIL
Overnight sheet. You covered Hall B.

DANA
I covered C. B was Tasha's till she walked off.

GAIL
Pelley's checks. Two and four.

DANA
It's not two yet.

GAIL
It's a box, Dana.

Dana looks at the box. At Pelley, chewing. At Gail's pen, cap off, offered across the counter.

DANA
I haven't done that round.

GAIL
Does he look okay?

Dana looks. He does.

GAIL (cont'd)
Then he'll look okay at two. Initial it and go home.

Dana takes the pen. Initials. Gail turns the page. Another box.

GAIL (cont'd)
Four a.m.

Dana's pen hovers. She initials.

Gail smiles the way a door closes.

EXT. MAGNOLIA COURT - PARKING LOT - MORNING

Seven a.m. An ambulance, back doors open. Dana, in street clothes, came back for the lanyard she left on the cart and stopped in the middle of the lot.

Mr. Pelley rolls past on a stretcher, face gray, one leg wrong. A PARAMEDIC reads off a clipboard to his partner.

PARAMEDIC
Facility says he was checked at two and four.

PARTNER
Somebody should have caught this.

The clipboard rides under the paramedic's arm. Dana's initials are on it. She knows exactly where.

Pelley's eyes find her. He says nothing. He has learned not to ask.

The doors shut.

INT. CARING HANDS PRIVATE DUTY - WAITING ROOM - DAY

TEN DAYS LATER

A TV on mute. Four CAREGIVERS in scrubs talk low. When Dana sits, they stop. They know.

RENEE (40s, tired, scrubs) opens a back door.

RENEE
Dana. A minute.

INT. CARING HANDS - RENEE'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

A desk, a chipped mug, a clock that stopped. Renee doesn't sit.

RENEE
Magnolia let you go. The state board hasn't ruled. Until it does, you can work.

DANA
Until it does.

RENEE
Live-in. Elderly stroke patient. Private family in Buckhead. Good money, meals, completion bonus.

DANA
Who's the family?

RENEE
Whitfield.

DANA
The foundation Whitfields?

RENEE
You've heard of them.

DANA
Everybody has. Why me?

RENEE
They want someone now.

DANA
Why now?

RENEE
Last caregiver left.

DANA
Why?

RENEE
Not my story to tell.

Dana waits. Renee gives her nothing.

DANA
Did they see my file?

RENEE
They saw what we sent.

Renee slides a card across the desk. An address. A time.

RENEE (cont'd)
Nine tomorrow. Take it or I've got other candidates.

Dana takes the card.

INT. GROCERY STORE - SELF-CHECKOUT - DAY

Dana scans cereal, rice, a bag of apples. The screen goes red. CARD DECLINED.

She tries again. Declined.

She takes the cereal off the belt. Then the apples. Leaves the rice.

INT. ROSA'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

A rental kitchen wiped to a shine. Landlord-proof. ROSA REYES (early 60s), once the household manager of a Buckhead home, lines unopened envelopes on the counter like place settings. At the table, LUCA (8, serious, small for his age) labels a cardboard house in block letters.

Dana enters with one bag. Sees the envelopes. Sets the bag on top of them.

ROSA
Seven.

DANA
I know.

ROSA
I'm counting so you know how many I'm not opening.

Luca holds up the house.

LUCA
Three bedrooms. Me, you, Abuela.

He caps the marker. Uncaps it. Adds a tiny fourth room.

DANA
Who's that for?

LUCA
The dog.

DANA
We don't have a dog.

LUCA
We don't have a fourth bedroom either.

Rosa slides the electric bill out from under the bag. Taps it.

ROSA
The fifteenth.

DANA
(not looking)
I got a job. Live-in. Stroke patient. Rich family.

ROSA
How rich?

DANA
Rent rich.

ROSA
That's not the same as good.

Dana dries a plate that's already dry.

ROSA (cont'd)
If they ask you to sign something you didn't see.

DANA
Mamá.

ROSA
I raised you careful. Not scared.

Luca slides the cardboard house toward Dana. The dog room faces the street.

LUCA
It has a window. So he can see you coming home.

Dana lifts it. Holds it like it's heavy.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - GATE - DAY

DAY ONE

A stone wall. An iron gate. A speaker box. Dana's worn sedan idles. She presses the button. Nobody speaks. The gate swings open on its own.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - DRIVE - CONTINUOUS

Old hardwoods over a climbing road. At the top, the house: half colonial, half glass, every window clean.

The lawn was mowed this week. The gravel is raked in lines. The silence is the loudest thing here.

A chime answers Dana's knock. Bright. The quiet after it isn't.

MARGOT BELL (58), housekeeper, starched apron, dry hands, opens the door.

MARGOT
Ms. Reyes. Come in out of the heat.

She takes Dana's jacket and folds it over her arm like it might break.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - FOYER - CONTINUOUS

A grandfather clock. From upstairs, a faint voice calls once. Nobody answers it.

MARGOT
Mrs. Whitfield has good mornings and quiet ones. This is a quiet one.

DANA
Is she awake?

MARGOT
Resting.

Dana knows the difference. She doesn't say so.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALL - CONTINUOUS

Margot leads. Kitchen, staff office, a medication cabinet with a lock, the key on Margot's ring. Now a narrow hall, a closed door.

MARGOT
Her room. The handle doesn't turn from inside.

DANA
Why not?

MARGOT
She wandered once. It upset everyone.

Dana crouches to the handle. Shallow scuffs at the base of the door, low, the height of a foot. Painted over. Painted over again. Still there.

DANA
Who did the paint?

MARGOT
I keep the house.

Dana stands. Margot opens the door.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

A high bed with a rail on the right, a small beige alarm unit clipped to it, its sticker curling at the corner: BATTERY ALARM. TEST WEEKLY. A wheeled tray. A window onto the garden. Across from the bed, a family portrait in oil: the Whitfields at their height. ELEANOR (silver hair, mouth set) with her hand on her daughter's shoulder.

ELEANOR WHITFIELD (72) sits propped against pillows, a blanket across her lap, her right hand curled against her thigh. Her eyes are open. They are not empty.

PRISCILLA WHITFIELD-VANCE (43), polished, calm, stands at the bedside reading a tablet.

PRISCILLA
Mother, this is Dana Reyes. The new nurse.

Eleanor doesn't turn.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
She'll help with your mornings and your medications.

Dana kneels to Eleanor's eye level.

DANA
Mrs. Whitfield. I'm Dana. I'll be here tonight and most nights.

A beat. Eleanor's face turns toward the voice. Not to her daughter. To the nurse.

Priscilla smooths the blanket. Under her hand, Eleanor's breathing changes. Her eyes lock on Priscilla's fingers.

PRISCILLA
She does this when she's overstimulated. It's one of her patterns.

Dana looks at the hand. At Eleanor's eyes. She says nothing.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Your agency says you're careful.

DANA
I chart what I see.

PRISCILLA
That's what I'm counting on.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - AFTERNOON

Dana has a blood pressure cuff, a thermometer and a clipboard of her own. Margot hovers at the door with a stack of folded towels nobody needs. Priscilla stays, tablet in hand.

DANA
I'd like to do a baseline. Vitals, skin, pressure points. Ten minutes.

PRISCILLA
Dr. Vance did one last week.

DANA
Then mine will match.

She slides the cuff on Eleanor's left arm. Her badge swings forward on its lanyard: DANA REYES, LPN. CARING HANDS. She talks to Eleanor, not to the room.

DANA (cont'd)
Cold cuff. Sorry.

She checks the heels. The hips. She lifts the blanket from the right hand. Cool, curled, the fingers locked. The thumb sits slightly apart from the rest.

DANA (cont'd)
Mrs. Whitfield, I'm going to hold up two things. Show me which one you'd like me to use.

She raises a silver hairbrush in one hand, a plastic comb in the other, a foot above the blanket.

Eleanor's eyes don't move. Her right thumb lifts a quarter inch toward the brush. Falls.

Dana keeps her face still. Swaps hands. The brush is on the other side now. She waits.

The thumb lifts. Toward the brush.

PRISCILLA
That's a reflex. It twitches when she's tired.

DANA
It twitched twice. Toward the same thing.

PRISCILLA
Coincidence.

Dana brushes Eleanor's hair, slowly, with the silver brush. Eleanor's eyes close. Priscilla watches Dana's hands, not Eleanor's face.

Dana's eyes drift to the rail. The beige alarm unit. She presses its red button.

Nothing. No tone. No light.

DANA
This is dead.

MARGOT
(too fast)
It's always been like that.

Dana turns the unit over. The battery door is open. Empty.

DANA
Somebody took the batteries out.

PRISCILLA
Mother kept setting it off. It upset her.

DANA
Being unable to call anyone upsets her more.

PRISCILLA
Margot, take that out of the room.

DANA
No.

A silence. Margot doesn't move.

DANA (cont'd)
If you want a safety device disabled, I need it in writing from Dr. Vance. Dated, signed, in the chart.

Priscilla smiles. It costs her something.

PRISCILLA
Of course. It isn't worth a fuss.

Dana pulls a penlight from her pocket. Unscrews it. Thumbs out two small batteries and fits them into the alarm unit. Holds the button down.

A shrill tone fills the room. Eleanor flinches. Her eyes go to the unit and stay there.

Dana lets go. The tone stops with her thumb.

She unclips the unit and clips it back on the rail lower down, snug against Eleanor's curled right hand, the red button an inch from the thumb.

She writes it in her notebook. Time. Alarm battery replaced. Tested. Working.

Priscilla sees the notebook. Sees where the unit sits now. Says nothing.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - LATER

A guest room made to a guest room's standard. Linen pressed. Towels folded. The radiator ticks.

Dana sets her bag on the bed. She doesn't unpack.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STUDY - LATER

Margot and Dana across a desk. A medication log between them. Two months of entries. Same hand. Same ink. Not one correction.

MARGOT
I keep the book. Dr. Vance signs.

DANA
I've charted nine years. I've never seen a log written by someone who never made a mistake.

MARGOT
I have good handwriting.

DANA
Margot.

Margot meets her eyes. Doesn't answer. Turns the page.

MARGOT
Cell service is best at the front gate. The house phone runs through the system. Leave the portrait where it is. She gets upset when things move.

DANA
What things?

MARGOT
Just leave it.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STAIRS - LATER

Dana descends. At the bottom, she turns and looks up. She can't see Eleanor's door.

She steps left. Steps right. Nothing. The staircase was built so that nobody standing here could ever know if that door is open or closed.

She files it.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT

The house has settled. A lamp. Dana at a small desk in the corner, a paperback open and unread. Eleanor sleeps.

Dana watches her breathe. Counts the seconds between breaths.

She opens the chart. Reads the entries on Eleanor's behavior. General. Nothing specific. Nothing that sounds like a person.

Eleanor's eyes are open. They've been open a while.

DANA
I'm here.

Eleanor's left hand moves. It pushes the chart toward Dana. Deliberate.

DANA (cont'd)
You want me to read it?

Eleanor blinks once. Yes.

Dana turns the chart over. Pulls a small spiral notebook from her pocket. Writes a time. Under it, OBSERVED. A line. Under that, ASSESSED. A line.

DANA (cont'd)
I'll keep my own notes.

Eleanor's eyes stay on the notebook.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - LATER

A bell rings. Eleanor's left hand is working at the bedside drawer. Dana is already up.

DANA
Mrs. Whitfield?

The door opens. Margot in a nightdress, a paper medication cup in her hand.

MARGOT
Nighttime agitation. Dr. Vance leaves an order for a small dose.

DANA
I'd like to see the order.

MARGOT
Over a quarter milligram?

DANA
Over my signature.

Margot doesn't move. Priscilla appears behind her, silk robe, hair tied back.

PRISCILLA
Margot is trying to help.

DANA
Show me the order. Then I'll give it.

PRISCILLA
In the morning. Adrian will walk you through it.

DANA
Tonight.

Priscilla studies her. Then, softly:

PRISCILLA
Margot. As prescribed.

Margot lifts the cup. Eleanor's left hand rises to push it away.

Priscilla catches the wrist. Steady. Practiced. Waits.

Eleanor swallows. Her eyes never leave Dana.

Dana writes. Time. OBSERVED: Patient refused cup with left hand. Wrist held by daughter. ASSESSED: Patient not combative.

Priscilla sees the notebook.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Please don't.

DANA
It's how I work.

Priscilla and Margot leave. Dana wedges a chair under the door handle.

She sits. Eleanor's hand finds her wrist and holds it.

On the desk, Dana's phone lights. MISSED CALL: LUCA. 8:02 PM. A voicemail. She turns the volume down to nothing and holds it to her ear.

LUCA (V.O.)
Mom. It's bedtime. You said before bed. Okay. Bye.

Dana lowers the phone. Eleanor's hand tightens on her wrist. Dana could slip it free. She doesn't.

One-thumbed, she types: Sorry baby. Tomorrow. She sends it.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - OFFICE - MORNING

DAY TWO

DR. ADRIAN VANCE (49), reading glasses, white coat over a knit tie, sits behind a desk with the chart open. Dana stands.

ADRIAN
The dose was within standard nighttime parameters.

DANA
The entry says combative. She was frightened.

ADRIAN
Ms. Reyes. This household has three specialists on her plan. I don't rewrite a chart because one nurse disagrees with an adjective.

He turns a page.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
I read your file from Magnolia Court.

DANA
I'm sure you did.

ADRIAN
A disputed entry doesn't disappear because you changed employers.

DANA
Is that a clinical observation or a warning?

ADRIAN
Both.

Dana holds his eye. She leaves.

Adrian watches the door close. He looks at his hands. They have been steady for twenty years. They are steady now.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Dana eats toast standing at the counter. Priscilla comes in already dressed, no tablet, no phone. She looks tired in a way she hasn't allowed yet.

PRISCILLA
I owe you an apology for last night.

Dana stops chewing.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
You were right to ask for the order. I'd have asked too. Adrian's charting can be blunt.

DANA
The entry said combative.

PRISCILLA
The chart reflects the treating physician's assessment. You're welcome to record your disagreement in your own notes. I'll tell Margot not to interfere.

It is so reasonable that Dana looks for the trap and doesn't find one.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Margot mentioned your son's school has an after-care waitlist.

DANA
Eight weeks.

PRISCILLA
The foundation has a children's fund. I made a call. He starts Monday. There's no application.

DANA
Why?

PRISCILLA
Because I'd want someone to do it for mine.

She sets a folded form on the counter. A Whitfield Foundation logo. A line for a parent's name, already filled in: LUCA REYES. Dana's name below it, typed.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Only the one signature. When you're ready.

She leaves. Dana looks at the form. At the typed name. She reads every word, twice, before she signs. Nothing is wrong with it.

That bothers her more.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Dana on the bed, phone to her ear. Her bag still packed.

ROSA (V.O.)
Money came through. It's not Friday's money.

DANA
It's this week's and next week's.

ROSA (V.O.)
What's the catch?

DANA
No catch. The family even got Luca into the foundation's after-care. No application. Starts Monday.

ROSA (V.O.)
Who asked them?

DANA
Nobody. It was a kindness.

ROSA (V.O.)
I ran a house in Buckhead for twenty-six years. When people like that say there is no application, it means they already decided where you belong.

DANA
It's school after-care, Mamá.

ROSA (V.O.)
Then why did she call before you did?

Dana has no answer for that.

DANA
I'll tell you when I find it.

She hangs up. She reaches into her bag for a charger and finds, folded flat, a small cardboard square. A window cut in it. A tiny word in block letters: DOG.

She sets it on the shelf above the radiator.

She unpacks.

DAY THREE

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - MORNING

Gray light through the window. Dana wakes on top of the covers, still dressed, the notebook under her hand.

She sits up. Above the door frame, a small black dome, the size of a golf ball. A pinhole of red light.

She stands on the desk chair. Looks into the lens from six inches away. She doesn't touch it.

She climbs down. Smooths the bedspread. Puts the notebook in her pocket.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - MORNING

Dana carries in a breakfast tray. She sets it on the wheeled table, then moves the table until it sits exactly under Eleanor's left hand.

Eleanor looks at the tray. At the distance she doesn't have to reach. At Dana.

Her fingers find the fork.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

Dana clears the bedside table. A water glass slips from her hand and shatters on the hardwood.

She kneels to gather the pieces.

A hand catches her sleeve. Eleanor's left. Not strong. Deliberate.

Dana looks up.

ELEANOR
(a breath, barely a word)
Help.

The door opens. Priscilla fills the frame.

PRISCILLA
What happened?

Eleanor's hand lets go. Her face turns to the wall.

DANA
I broke a glass.

PRISCILLA
Are you cut?

DANA
No.

PRISCILLA
I'll send Margot.

She goes. Dana stays on her knees, looking at the woman in the bed.

Eleanor looks at the window. Not at the door.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - EVENING

Dana at the desk, her phone propped against the lamp. Above the door, the red light. She keeps her voice bright and low.

On the screen, LUCA at Rosa's kitchen table, a pencil behind his ear, a division worksheet in front of him.

LUCA
It doesn't go.

DANA
It goes. Carry the four.

He carries the four. Looks up.

LUCA
Why are you talking like the library?

DANA
Library voice. It's a quiet house.

LUCA
Abuela says it's a big house.

DANA
It's big.

LUCA
Is it scary?

Dana's eyes go to the dome. Back to the screen.

DANA
It's quiet.

Luca holds up his cardboard house to the lens. Block letters on every wall. One window cut in the roof, with nothing in it.

LUCA
It still has a hole where the dog goes.

Dana looks at the shelf above the radiator. The cardboard square. She doesn't take it down. Not under the camera.

DANA
I know where it is.

LUCA
Don't lose it.

DANA
I won't.

Off screen, Rosa's voice. Bath. Luca pulls a face and leans toward the lens until his whole eye fills it.

LUCA
Goodnight, library voice.

He's gone. Dana sits with the dark phone against her forehead for exactly three seconds. Then she straightens, composed for the dome, and opens her notebook.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Dark. Dana sits on the floor against the bed, away from the dome, her phone cupped to her mouth. A voicemail beep.

DANA
(whispering)
Hi, Mamá. It's me. It's fine. I don't know what this house is yet.

She ends the call. Sits in the dark. The tiny red light doesn't blink.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DINING ROOM - MORNING

A long table set for one. Dana enters with her coffee and finds Priscilla already seated, in cashmere, a phone face down beside her plate.

PRISCILLA
Sit. You've been up since five.

Dana sits. Priscilla pours her coffee from a silver pot.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
I hope you'll come to know what this house is.

Dana's cup stops an inch from her mouth.

Priscilla turns her phone over to check the time. On the screen, a grid of nine small camera feeds. Foyer. Kitchen. Terrace. Dana's room, empty, the bed made.

Priscilla turns the phone back over.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Eat something.

Dana sets the cup down very gently.

INT. ROSA'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

DAY FOUR

The kitchen smells like garlic and cumin. A pot of arroz con pollo on the back burner. Rosa, an apron over her church blouse, stirs with one hand and swats at Luca's fingers with the other.

ROSA
Ay, Luca, no. Wait for your mother.

Dana comes in with her bag and a gallon of milk. Luca hits her at the knees.

LUCA
You came home.

DANA
For lunch.

ROSA
For lunch. Mira, flaca. You're thin.

She presses a plate into Dana's hands before Dana has her coat off.

ROSA (cont'd)
Siéntate. Eat.

Dana eats standing up. Rosa watches every bite.

On the counter, one envelope, opened and flattened. A yellow sheet. Rosa taps it.

ROSA (cont'd)
Señor Haddad came by. The fifteenth, he says. The fifteenth or the other paper.

DANA
I'll have it.

ROSA
How?

DANA
First paycheck is this week.

Rosa studies her. Dana reaches for a second spoonful and doesn't meet her eyes.

ROSA
And the family? The rich one?

DANA
They need a body in the house.

ROSA
That's a job. It's not a reason.

Luca drags the cardboard house across the table. The fourth room has a doorframe now.

LUCA
Mom. Look. A door for Casa.

DANA
Who's Casa?

LUCA
The dog. Abuela said I can name him.

ROSA
I said when we have a dog. Then you can name him.

LUCA
When is when?

ROSA
When your mother stops looking at her phone.

Dana puts the phone face down. Luca grins.

Rosa takes the plate. Scrapes the last rice into foil. Folds the foil into a neat packet and slides it into Dana's coat pocket.

ROSA (cont'd)
For the car.

DANA
Mamá.

ROSA
For later. You think they feed you there?

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Dana on the bed, the foil packet open on her knee. She eats cold rice with her fingers.

The little red light above the door. She looks at it. She licks a finger.

Her phone buzzes. Luca's voice, small and sleepy.

LUCA (V.O.)
Casa says goodnight.

DANA
(whispering)
Tell him goodnight.

She ends the call. The dome above the door doesn't blink.

She opens the laptop. The search bar: Eleanor Whitfield.

A press photo, eight years old. Eleanor at a podium, a bank of microphones, her husband at her side, Priscilla a step behind. The headline: PHARMA BOARD MEMBER TURNS WHISTLEBLOWER.

Scroll. A Senate hearing. A standing ovation. The Whitfield Foundation logo behind a gala.

Scroll. A stroke-awareness luncheon, three years ago. Eleanor standing. Speaking.

Scroll. A local business profile from two months before her stroke. Eleanor shaking hands with a hospital administrator. Smiling for the camera.

Dana opens a blank document. Types a date. Types another.

She closes the laptop before the screen can show the document name.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - MORNING

DAY FIVE

A laminated alphabet card, a soft pencil, a pad of paper on the tray. Dana sits. Waits.

DANA
Use it, ignore it. Your call.

Eleanor looks at the card. Looks at the door. Pushes it away with the back of her hand.

Dana leaves it where it lands.

LATER

The card has moved an inch toward Eleanor.

LATER STILL

Eleanor's left hand drifts to the card. A finger finds a letter. Stops. Eleanor looks at Dana.

DANA (cont'd)
Take your time.

The finger finds another letter. Another.

DANA (cont'd)
P. E. N.

Eleanor's hand trembles. She looks at the door, back at the card.

DANA (cont'd)
Pencil.

Eleanor's eyes close. Yes.

Dana puts the soft pencil in Eleanor's left hand. The grip is wrong. The letters come out like a seismograph. Two letters. The pad tears.

Eleanor drops the pencil.

DANA (cont'd)
Card, then. Pencil later.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

Adrian takes Eleanor's pulse, two fingers on the left wrist. Dana stands at the foot of the bed with her notebook.

ADRIAN
Rate's steady.

He doesn't look at Eleanor. He looks at the monitor, the watch, the chart.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
Does she speak to you?

Dana keeps her face neutral.

DANA
No.

Adrian's shoulders drop. Not relief exactly. Something smaller.

ADRIAN
Good. It's better that she doesn't. It only frustrates her.

He releases the wrist. His own hand shakes, a tremor so slight only Dana sees it.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
My wife is under a great deal of pressure.

DANA
I can see that.

ADRIAN
I'd ask you to keep that in mind.

He leaves. Eleanor's eyes follow him out. Then they come back to Dana.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - MORNING

The card. Eleanor's finger moves before Dana sits.

CLOSE ON the letters under her fingertip.

DANA
D. O. N. T.

Eleanor's finger drags to the next row.

DANA (cont'd)
S. I. G. N.

Dana looks up. Eleanor's eyes are hard and clear.

DANA (cont'd)
Don't sign what?

The door opens. Margot enters with the morning pills.

MARGOT
Time for her medications.

Eleanor's hand closes into a fist on the card. Dana steps back. Margot gives the pills. Dana writes the time.

After Margot goes, Dana crouches by the bed.

DANA
Don't sign what, Eleanor?

Eleanor's finger finds a letter. T. R. A. N.

Her hand shakes. It drops.

DANA (cont'd)
Transfer.

Eleanor's eyes fill. She nods once.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

DAY SIX

A rolling case of picture cards on the tray. KEZIA ADAMS (50s, cardigan, reading glasses on a beaded chain), a speech-language pathologist, kneels at Eleanor's bedside. Priscilla in the armchair. Margot at the door. Dana by the window, notebook closed in her hand.

ADAMS
Dr. Vance's plan lists me for monthly visits. This is my first.

DANA
His plan lists three specialists. You're the first I've met.

Priscilla's eyes flick to Dana. Back to the tablet.

ADAMS
Mrs. Whitfield, I'm going to set two words in front of you. ANIMAL on your left. OBJECT on your right. I'll show you a picture, and you tell me which kind it is. Look at the word.

She stands a card on the tray facing Eleanor, its back to the room. Adams can't see it. Nobody can but Eleanor.

Eleanor's eyes travel right. OBJECT.

Adams turns the card around. A clock.

Adams says nothing. Draws another card. Stands it up.

Eleanor's eyes go left. ANIMAL. Adams turns the card. A heron.

Adams sets it down very gently.

ADAMS (cont'd)
That response is purposeful.

PRISCILLA
She's tired.

ADAMS
Then I need a full assessment.

PRISCILLA
We don't push when she's tired.

DANA
Then let her tell us.

Adams looks at Dana. Then she takes two more cards from the case. YES. NO. She sets them where Eleanor can see.

ADAMS
Mrs. Whitfield. Are you tired?

Eleanor's eyes go to NO. They stay there.

PRISCILLA
She doesn't understand the question.

ADAMS
She just understood three.

PRISCILLA
(pleasantly)
Kezia, I appreciate it. There are things you learn to recognize in your own mother.

DANA
I recognize her trying.

Priscilla rises. Smooths her skirt.

PRISCILLA
Margot. Her afternoon dose.

Margot goes out. Comes back with a paper cup.

ADAMS
Is that sedating?

PRISCILLA
It's for comfort.

ADAMS
I'd like to finish before she's medicated.

PRISCILLA
You have.

Adams looks at Eleanor. Eleanor looks at NO.

Adams packs the case slowly. Among the cards, one blank index card. She writes a single word on it with her hand curled around the pen, tilts it toward Eleanor and no one else. Eleanor's eyes read it. Adams slides the card into her cardigan pocket.

At the door Dana walks her out.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALL - CONTINUOUS

ADAMS
(low)
Priscilla signs my referrals. I can't come back unless she calls me.

DANA
She won't.

ADAMS
Then you call me.

She slips a card into Dana's notebook. KEZIA ADAMS, SPEECH-LANGUAGE PATHOLOGY. A cell number in ballpoint on the back.

ADAMS (cont'd)
I showed her one word. Nobody else saw it. When she's rested, call me on video and let her spell it. I'll say nothing until she's done.

DANA
That proves something?

ADAMS
It proves one thing. It's a start.

Through the open door behind them, Priscilla stands over the bed with the paper cup. She is watching the card disappear into the notebook.

She smiles. Dana doesn't.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ADRIAN'S OFFICE - DAY

A fax tray beside the desk. Adrian lifts the top page. Reads. Kezia Adams's letterhead: findings consistent with purposeful communication, a full evaluation recommended within seventy-two hours.

Priscilla reads over his shoulder. She doesn't touch the page. She lays a fresh sheet of the practice's letterhead in front of him and uncaps his pen for him.

PRISCILLA
Reviewed. Findings inconclusive. Fatigue noted.

ADRIAN
She's a licensed clinician.

PRISCILLA
And you're the treating physician.

He holds the pen. The tremor Dana saw is back.

He writes. Signs.

Priscilla folds Adams's letter in half, in half again, and drops it into the shredder at her feet.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Margot washes lunch dishes. Dana dries beside her.

MARGOT
Agency called yesterday. Family called them first.

DANA
I figured.

MARGOT
Theresa asked too many questions.

DANA
The last caregiver.

MARGOT
Six months. Eleanor trusted her. Priscilla asked her to sign a chart entry she hadn't seen. She said no. Next week, a complaint. Gone.

Margot hands over a plate. Dana takes it. Taped under the plate, a torn corner of paper with a phone number in pencil.

MARGOT (cont'd)
I'm not telling you anything.

DANA
I know.

MARGOT
Good.

She goes back to the sink. Her hands are shaking in the water.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - FRONT GATE - DAY

Dana stands at the gate with the torn paper in one hand and her phone in the other. The call rings six times. A click.

THERESA (V.O.)
Who gave you this number?

DANA
Somebody who didn't.

THERESA (V.O.)
Margot.

DANA
I'm in the room you were in. I'm trying not to lose what you lost.

A long silence on the line. Wind in the trees.

THERESA (V.O.)
Is there still a dome over the bedroom door?

DANA
Yes.

THERESA (V.O.)
It hears, too.

Dana glances back up the hill at the house.

DANA
What happened to you?

THERESA (V.O.)
I asked to see the lift. The agency stopped calling. I drive for a delivery app now.

DANA
Will you give a statement?

THERESA (V.O.)
Do you have anything that isn't your word?

DANA
Nothing yet.

THERESA (V.O.)
A photograph isn't a person. She'll say you made it up. You need the paper itself, and someone who isn't you.

DANA
And if I get that?

THERESA (V.O.)
Then be ready to lose the job before you win. And keep one copy where she can't find it.

The line goes dead. Dana lowers the phone and stands there with the wind.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - GREAT ROOM - DAY

DAY SEVEN

A foundation luncheon. Six guests at a long table. At each place, a Whitfield Foundation brochure and a printed agenda. The top line of the agenda: FOUNDATION REVIEW, FRIDAY, 10:00 A.M. Adrian at one end. Priscilla at the other.

PRISCILLA
The hardest part of caregiving is the moment your parent becomes your child.

Murmurs. A donor dabs her eye. Dana stands in the service doorway with a water pitcher.

HELEN (60S)
I'd hoped to see Eleanor today.

PRISCILLA
She'd hate being seen on a bad day. She was always so proud.

HELEN
Of course.

WALTER (60s, reading glasses pushed into his hair) taps his brochure.

WALTER
Priscilla, small thing. The accessibility completion report reached my inbox on the fourth. The lift didn't ship until last week. I only ask because the reviewer will.

PRISCILLA
Walter, you read everything. That's why we keep you.

Light laughter. Priscilla lets it settle.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
The report anticipated completion. Harbor has been wonderful about timing.

MARY (60S)
Will Eleanor join Friday by video? It would mean so much to the board.

A pause so small only Dana, in the doorway, catches it.

PRISCILLA
We'll see how she is.

MARY
Your mother is why I give. When she testified, it changed how I thought about accountability.

PRISCILLA
Mother's courage was the easy part. Mine came after.

Applause, soft and warm.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Directly above. Eleanor lies still. The faint sound of the applause comes through the floor.

Her left hand closes into a fist and stays closed.

EXT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - REAR TERRACE - DAY

Dana carries a stack of brochures and leans on the railing. In the corner of the terrace, a wheelchair lift sits in a shipping crate. The plastic is still wrapped around its safety rail.

She opens the brochure. A photo of the lift. A caption: Recent accessibility improvement. Project complete. Paid in full.

She looks at the crate. A shipping label: HARBOR ACCESS PARTNERS. DELIVERED LAST WEEK. In small print on the brochure, the same name: Installed by Harbor Access Partners.

At the crate. At the brochure. At the crate.

Above her, a tap on glass. Eleanor's window. Her left knuckle, twice.

Dana looks up. Eleanor's face is a pale shape behind the pane.

Dana lifts the brochure so Eleanor can see it. Eleanor taps twice again.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - FRONT GATE - LATE AFTERNOON

The one spot with a signal. Dana, the Foundation brochure folded in her fist, the board roster printed on the back. She dials. Golf-course wind on the other end.

WALTER (V.O.)
This is Walter.

DANA
Walter, it's Dana Reyes. Mrs. Whitfield's nurse. You asked about the Harbor invoices at lunch.

WALTER (V.O.)
The nurse. Priscilla speaks very highly of you.

DANA
The lift is still in its crate on the terrace. The brochure says paid in full. I can send you photographs.

A silence on the line. Longer than golf.

WALTER (V.O.)
That's a serious thing to say about a family that has given this city a great deal.

DANA
I'm not saying it. The crate is.

WALTER (V.O.)
Let me raise it with Priscilla first. Quietly. She'd want the chance to correct it before the review.

DANA
Please don't do that.

WALTER (V.O.)
I've known her twenty years, Ms. Reyes. Let her fix it.

He's gone. Dana lowers the phone.

In the gatehouse, RAY (50s, blazer, an ex-cop's shoulders) watches her through the glass. He writes something on a clipboard. Time, probably.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

Dana folds linen in the corner, out of the way. Priscilla sits at the bedside with a cup and a teaspoon, feeding her mother as you feed a child. Patient. Practiced. Tender.

PRISCILLA
You used to say tea was the only honest thing in a house. You never said what the rest was.

Eleanor's eyes go to the card on the tray. Without breaking rhythm, Priscilla turns it face down.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Not at tea.

She wipes a drop from Eleanor's chin with a folded napkin.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
I read your testimony every year on my birthday. Sixty-one pages. Do you know how many times I'm in it?

Eleanor says nothing. Can't.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Once. My daughter, who is at school.

The spoon rests against the saucer. Eleanor's eyes close.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
I've been at school a long time, Mother.

She sees Dana watching. The smile arrives complete.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Thank you, Dana. That'll be all.

Dana goes. In the hall she looks back through the gap in the door. Eleanor's left hand drags across the tray. A nail catches the edge of the card and flips it face up.

Priscilla turns it face down again. Presses her palm flat on it. Holds it there.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT

The card. Eleanor's finger is already moving.

DANA
V. E. N. D.

She stops. Eleanor looks at her.

DANA (cont'd)
Vendor. Harbor Access?

Eleanor blinks once.

DANA (cont'd)
The lift is still in its crate. You found out, and you asked for records. Then the stroke.

Eleanor's hand trembles on the card. She doesn't blink.

Dana writes it down. Stops.

DANA (cont'd)
Where are the records?

Eleanor's finger crosses the card. H. I. D. E.

DANA (cont'd)
Hide.

Another row. P. A. P. E. R. S.

DANA (cont'd)
You hid papers.

Eleanor's eyes lift. Past Dana. To the wall behind her.

Dana turns. The family portrait.

DANA (cont'd)
You hid papers in the portrait.

Eleanor closes her eyes. Yes.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT (LATER)

Past two a.m. Eleanor lies awake, her eyes on the portrait. No dome above this door. Priscilla's rule: Mother's room is private. Dana has wondered who that rule protects.

Dana lowers the lamp. She drags the desk chair to the wall. Climbs onto it. Her fingertips touch the frame.

Footsteps in the hall. A cup rattles on a saucer.

Dana steps down fast and shoves the chair toward the desk, an inch too far.

The door opens. Margot, in a nightdress, a paper cup in her hand.

MARGOT
You're up.

DANA
Always.

Margot's eyes go to the chair, out of place. To the portrait.

MARGOT
What were you doing?

DANA
The curtain. It was catching the light on her face.

Margot looks at the curtain. Closed. She looks at Dana.

MARGOT
Chamomile. Not for her.

She sets the cup on the desk.

MARGOT (cont'd)
I'd leave things where they are.

She goes. Eleanor's finger is already on the card. N. O. W.

DANA
She'll come back.

Eleanor's finger doesn't move. N. O. W.

Dana climbs onto the chair. Lifts the portrait off its hook. Behind it, bare drywall and a thin metal seam at the base of the frame.

She sets the portrait on the carpet. Runs a fingernail along the seam. It gives.

A shallow drawer, pressed shut. She pulls. An envelope. A small brass key.

Inside the envelope: invoices from Harbor Access Partners, a printed ledger, a notary stamp. In the margin of every invoice, a strong slanted hand in blue ink. No lift installed. Who is H.? Dated nine days before the stroke.

Under the envelope, a thin folder tied with string. HALLAM, in the same hand.

Eleanor's finger is on the card. N. O.

DANA (cont'd)
No what?

Eleanor holds her eyes. The finger doesn't move.

Dana unties the string.

She lays each page on the bed and photographs it. One. Two. Eleven. Twenty. The Hallam folder last.

She slides everything back. Rehangs the portrait. Straightens it with two fingers.

ELEANOR (O.S.)
(a thread of breath)
Careful.

Dana turns. Eleanor's eyes are open.

DANA
Always.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - DRIVE - NIGHT

Dana walks the long drive in the dark, phone held high, the signal bars climbing as she nears the gate. A progress bar crawls across the screen. Uploading.

In the gatehouse, a NIGHT GUARD (50s) watches her through the glass. He steps out, thumbs hooked in his belt.

NIGHT GUARD
Everything all right, ma'am?

DANA
Signal. My kid.

NIGHT GUARD
Phone's better here than at the house.

DANA
I noticed.

NIGHT GUARD
Funny thing about that.

He glances up the hill at the house. Says nothing else. Goes back into the gatehouse and opens a logbook. Writes. Time. Her name.

The progress bar fills. Dana lowers the phone and doesn't look at him on her way back up.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - MORNING

THE NEXT MORNING

Dana at the bedside. The card sits between them, untouched.

DANA
I read the Hallam folder. You told me not to.

Eleanor's face doesn't move.

DANA (cont'd)
Eight months. You knew what the pills were doing and you waited.

A long beat. Eleanor's finger crosses the card. W. A. I. T. E. D.

DANA (cont'd)
Waited.

Eleanor's finger crosses the card again. N. A. M. E.

DANA (cont'd)
For the name.

Eleanor's eyes fill. She doesn't look away.

DANA (cont'd)
You pointed me at the invoices and steered me off that folder. You let me think I was helping the clean one.

Eleanor's finger finds one letter at a time. A. S. H. A. M. E. D.

DANA (cont'd)
Ashamed.

Eleanor nods once.

Dana sits back. The notebook is closed on her knee.

DANA (cont'd)
At my last job I initialed rounds I never did. A man broke his hip. I know what a signature costs. I'm not going to tell you ours are the same. They aren't.

Eleanor's hand moves toward Dana's. Stops an inch short.

DANA (cont'd)
I'm angry with you. I'm still not leaving you here.

Eleanor's eyes close. She nods.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT

THAT NIGHT

Dana turns Eleanor, checks the heels, charts the vitals. She says nothing that isn't clinical.

DANA
Mrs. Whitfield. Water.

Eleanor's eyes follow her. Mrs. Whitfield. Not Eleanor. Eleanor's left hand finds the card and pushes it an inch toward Dana.

Dana slides it back within Eleanor's reach. She doesn't take the apology. She doesn't take the card away.

She dims the lamp. She sits at the desk with the paperback open and unread.

Eleanor stares at the ceiling. A tear runs sideways into her hair. Dana sees it. Doesn't move.

After a long time:

DANA (cont'd)
(not turning)
Ms. Adams wants you to spell her word on a video call tomorrow. It isn't for me. It's so somebody besides me knows. Whether you do it is up to you.

Eleanor's head turns.

A beat. Eleanor's finger lies on the card. Then it taps once. Yes.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

THREE DAYS TO THE REVIEW

Blinds half down. Dana props her phone against the water pitcher, lens on the bed and the card. A video call.

On the screen, KEZIA ADAMS in a parked car, reading glasses on their beaded chain. A recording dot. A clock in the corner: 9:14 A.M.

KEZIA (V.O.)
I'm here. I won't say a word until she's done.

DANA
(to Eleanor)
Ms. Adams showed you a word. Whenever you're ready.

Eleanor looks at the phone. At the card.

Her finger finds a letter. L.

Dana writes it in her notebook. Doesn't say it aloud.

A. N. T. E. R. N.

Dana turns the notebook toward the lens.

CLOSE ON THE PAGE. LANTERN.

On the screen, Kezia takes off her glasses.

KEZIA (V.O.)
That's my word.

Dana lets out a breath.

KEZIA (V.O.) (cont'd)
I'll write it up. A witnessed, time-stamped response to a word only I knew. It's one observation, Dana. It isn't a diagnosis. It's enough to ask a county caseworker to come and look.

DANA
Will she?

KEZIA (V.O.)
I'm calling this afternoon.

The call ends. Dana looks at Eleanor. Eleanor looks back.

DANA
Thank you.

Eleanor's finger moves again. S. O. R. R. Y.

Dana reads it.

DANA (cont'd)
Not yet.

But she takes Eleanor's left hand and holds it. That's the answer.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - AFTERNOON

Dana brushes Eleanor's hair with the silver brush. Sets the card square on the tray. Leans down.

DANA
A county caseworker is coming at three. Ms. Adams called it in. She isn't family and she isn't me. She can ask you anything.

Eleanor's finger taps the card once. Her breathing is quick.

The door opens. Priscilla, dressed in cream, a tray of tea in her hands. Margot behind her with the paper cup.

PRISCILLA
Mother's had a hard day.

DANA
She's been alert since breakfast. I charted noon and one.

PRISCILLA
Dr. Vance revised her afternoon order.

She holds out a sheet. Dana reads. Adrian's signature. Time: 1:10 P.M. An increased sedative.

DANA
Not today.

PRISCILLA
It's a physician's order, Dana.

Margot lifts the cup. Priscilla catches Eleanor's wrist. Steady. Practiced. Waits.

Eleanor's eyes find Dana's. She swallows.

Downstairs, a chime.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - LATER

MS. LOWRY (40s, county lanyard, a binder) kneels at the bed. Priscilla stands at the foot, gracious. Adrian by the window, looking at the floor. Dana at the door.

Eleanor's head rests on the pillow. Her lids sag. Her left hand lies slack on the card.

LOWRY
Mrs. Whitfield? Can you hear me?

The lids flutter. A finger twitches toward the card. Doesn't get there.

LOWRY (cont'd)
Does she usually answer yes or no?

PRISCILLA
On good days.

LOWRY
(to Dana)
You made the report?

DANA
A speech therapist did. I'm the nurse. This morning Eleanor spelled a word on a video call. I have the recording.

She lifts her phone.

LOWRY
I can't evaluate recordings. I can observe the patient.

PRISCILLA
That recording was made by the employee who controls my mother's medications. I'd rather not say more. Ms. Reyes is a lovely nurse in a difficult period. Her last facility has an open complaint with the state board.

Lowry looks at Dana.

LOWRY
Is that accurate?

DANA
Yes. It's about initials I put on a chart. This isn't about that.

LOWRY
(writing)
Doctor, anything to add?

Adrian doesn't lift his eyes.

ADRIAN
The orders are in the chart.

Lowry closes the binder.

LOWRY
I'll note that Mrs. Whitfield wasn't able to participate today, that a medication was administered per the physician's order, and that the reporting parties have unresolved concerns of their own. I'll follow up in thirty days.

DANA
She won't be here in thirty days.

LOWRY
I can only act on what I observe.

She gathers the binder. At the door she stops beside Dana, her back to the room, and tucks a card into Dana's palm.

LOWRY (cont'd)
(low)
Today I saw a woman who couldn't answer me. That isn't the same as a woman in danger. If her condition changes, call 911. Do not wait for my follow-up.

DANA
What counts as changed?

LOWRY
Something I can watch happen.

She goes. Priscilla follows to walk her out, her voice warm on the stairs.

Adrian stays a moment at the window. He looks at Dana once, and away.

Dana crosses to the bed. Eleanor's eyes are barely open. Dana puts the card back under her hand.

DANA
Save your strength.

Eleanor's lids close. Dana holds the hand.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STUDY - LATE AFTERNOON

Priscilla behind the desk. Dana in the chair across. On the blotter, side by side: a printout from Magnolia Court's incident report, and an agency form.

PRISCILLA
I do research on everyone who comes near my mother.

She taps the first page. Dana's name. Dana's initials, circled.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
You signed for two checks you didn't do. A man broke his hip. You reported your supervisor and lost your job.

Dana doesn't move.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
That's why I hired you.

DANA
Because I'd already signed something.

PRISCILLA
Because you understand how fragile a record is.

She lets that sit. Then, lightly:

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Margot tells me you were up on a chair at two in the morning, last week.

DANA
The curtain.

PRISCILLA
Of course. The gatehouse says you like the signal at the front gate. At two forty-one in the morning.

Dana says nothing.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
The county caseworker was lovely, wasn't she? She'll follow up in thirty days. And Ms.
(MORE)

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Adams has been reassigned. Her office called to apologize for the confusion.

Dana's hand, on her knee, closes.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
I've moved Mother's papers somewhere safer. She hid so many things she was never well enough to remember.

Dana's face stays still. Her hand, on her knee, does not.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Sign this one, and you leave with your reputation and a bonus.

She turns the agency form to face Dana. Persistent confusion. Threatening behavior.

Then she slides a cashier's check across the desk. Dana reads the number. It's the rent, plus the arrears, plus a little more. Exactly.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
My mother will be moved to Cedar Glen on Friday morning either way. You'd be gone before she noticed.

Dana looks at the check. At the number. At her own hand on her knee.

DANA
She wasn't combative.

PRISCILLA
On paper she'll be whatever the paper says.

Dana stands. She leaves the check. She leaves the form.

At the door:

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
How's Luca?

Dana stops. Doesn't turn.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
The after-care staff tell me he's very polite. Eight years old. He's in your agency file, you know.

Dana closes the door softly behind her.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - FRONT GATE - AFTERNOON

The one spot with a signal. Dana stands with her hands on her knees, breathing. Her phone buzzes. A voicemail.

BOARD INVESTIGATOR (V.O.)
Ms. Reyes, this is the State Board of Nursing. We've received Magnolia Court's incident report with your initials. We'll need a written statement from you within ten days. This is a courtesy call.

The message ends. She plays it again. Then she opens the dial pad. Types her mother's number. Her thumb hovers.

She closes the dial pad.

EXT. CHAMBLEE ELEMENTARY - AFTER-CARE PICKUP - LATE AFTERNOON

A strip of parked minivans along Buford Highway. Kids in hoodies spill out through the doors. Rosa waits at the curb with TIA LUPE (60s, church shoes, a rolling cart of groceries).

Luca bounds out, backpack bumping. Behind him, a gray sedan idles at the curb with its flashers on.

A WOMAN (30s, lanyard, pressed blouse) steps out of the sedan holding a canvas tote with a Whitfield Foundation logo. She crouches to Luca's height.

WOMAN
Luca? The foundation sent me. I can drive you home.

Rosa is there before the sentence finishes. She takes Luca by the shoulder and moves him behind her hip.

ROSA
He walks with me.

WOMAN
Your mom said it was fine.

ROSA
My daughter said no such thing.

WOMAN
(smiling, to Luca)
This is for you. Tell Casa hello. Tell your mom Mrs. Whitfield-Vance says hello too.

Luca's face goes blank. Nobody outside the family knows the dog's name.

She sets the tote on the curb. Rosa doesn't touch it.

The woman gets in the sedan. It pulls out. Rosa already has her phone up, photographing the plate. Then she lifts the tote by its handle with two fingers, like evidence.

TIA LUPE
Ay, Rosa.

ROSA
(low)
She knew the dog.

INT. ROSA'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - EVENING

Rosa on a stepstool, hauling pots down from the top shelf. Luca on the floor with a rolling suitcase, trying to fit the cardboard house.

ROSA
No. It doesn't fit. Leave Casa.

LUCA
He'll be scared.

ROSA
He's cardboard.

LUCA
He'll be scared of the dark.

ROSA
Then we carry him.

She hands Luca the house. Then takes the big pot off the shelf and sets it on the counter with her whole body.

ROSA (cont'd)
La olla buena. Tía Carmen doesn't have a good pot.

She dials. Holds the phone to her ear.

ROSA (cont'd)
Carmen? Sí. Voy para allá. Con el niño. Sí, esta noche. Te explico.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - FRONT GATE - DUSK

The one spot with a signal. Dana stands with her phone held up, a FaceTime ringing. Rosa's face fills the screen, kitchen light behind her.

ROSA
Look at this.

She turns the phone. The Foundation tote on the kitchen counter. Then a photo of a license plate.

ROSA (cont'd)
She knew the dog's name.

Dana's face doesn't change. Her thumb tightens on the phone.

DANA
Mamá, send me the plate.

ROSA
Already did.

DANA
Take Luca to Carmen's. Tonight. Don't go home till I call.

ROSA
Mija.

DANA
Please.

Rosa looks at her through the screen for a long time.

ROSA
You tell me before it becomes running.

DANA
I will.

Rosa hangs up. Dana stands at the gate, the screen going dark in her hand.

She scrolls. A press release on the Whitfield Foundation from eight years ago. Contact: Det. L. Ortiz, APD Financial Crimes.

She dials.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Ortiz.

DANA
My name is Dana Reyes. I'm the live-in nurse for Eleanor Whitfield.

A beat on the line. A chair squeaks.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Go on.

DANA
I have records from inside the house. Vendor payments. A ledger with a notary seal. I have photographs. And a plate number. A woman handed my eight-year-old a Whitfield Foundation tote at school.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Send the plate.

Dana sends it. A moment. Keys clicking on the other end.

ORTIZ (V.O.) (cont'd)
Leased to the foundation. Is she in danger tonight?

DANA
I don't know. They're moving her Friday morning.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
I can't act on photographs. I need the originals, and I need someone with a license who isn't you to see what you've seen.

DANA
A speech therapist saw her respond and recorded a second test. A county caseworker came yesterday and Eleanor was sedated. Kezia Adams.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Spell it.

Dana does.

ORTIZ (V.O.) (cont'd)
I'll reach out to her. You don't do my job and I won't do yours.

DANA
Before you hear it from them. Magnolia Court. I initialed two checks I didn't do. A patient was hurt.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Anything else about it?

DANA
I reported my supervisor. I lost my job. That's all of it.

A pause. Then:

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Keep writing everything down. What you saw, what you think. Different lines.

DANA
Already do.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Good.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - LAUNDRY ROOM - EVENING

Margot folds a fitted sheet into a perfect square. Priscilla appears in the doorway with a stack of towels she doesn't need.

PRISCILLA
Margot. I'm so sorry to raise this.

Margot keeps folding.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
The county called about Daniel's matter. The eighteen thousand. They tell me the statute is still open. I told them it was a family affair. I'd hate for that to change.

MARGOT
It hasn't changed.

PRISCILLA
Not yet. Dana's count tonight. It needs her signature, and it needs to say four ten.

Margot's hands stop.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
Just so Adrian's records are tidy.

She sets the towels on the folding table. Leaves.

Margot stands with the square of linen. Her fingers press the folds flat. Again. Again.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - KITCHEN - EVENING

Dana alone at the counter, phone propped against the sugar bowl, Rosa's voice coming out of it from the road.

ROSA (V.O.)
Tía Carmen has a landlord who doesn't care about her either. We'll be fine.

DANA
Are you eating?

ROSA (V.O.)
I'm driving. Luca's eating.

A beat.

ROSA (V.O.) (cont'd)
Dana. There's a paper on the door. Haddad. I took a picture.

A photo arrives. A yellow sheet taped to a screen door. Pay or quit. Five days.

Dana stares at it.

Margot enters with a clipboard, the cabinet key on her ring.

MARGOT
Monthly count. I need your signature.

DANA
(on the phone)
Mamá, hold on.

ROSA (V.O.)
Luca wants to say goodnight.

LUCA (V.O.)
Buenas noches, Mom. Casa says too.

DANA
Goodnight, baby. Goodnight, Casa.

She ends the call. Looks at the clipboard. A tally sheet. Pill counts in rows, a signature line with Dana's name already typed under it. Beside the line, a time already filled in: 4:10 P.M.

DANA (cont'd)
It's almost seven.

MARGOT
It's the count for the afternoon.

DANA
Then I'll count it with you.

Margot hesitates. Then she unlocks the cabinet.

Dana counts the evening tablets into a paper cup, one at a time, out loud. Twenty-seven. She sets the cup beside the clipboard.

The sheet says twenty-two.

DANA (cont'd)
That's five.

Margot doesn't look at her. At the far end of the hall, in the dark, a pale tablet glow. Priscilla, reading, not reading.

MARGOT
(barely audible)
Please.

Dana looks at the glow. At Margot's hand shaking on the pen. She knows what a refusal costs this woman tonight. She knows what a signature costs her.

She holds out her hand. Margot gives her the pen.

Under the typed line Dana writes, in her own hand: COUNTED 27 AT 6:47 P.M. SHEET SHOWS 22 AT 4:10 P.M. She signs beneath it. D. REYES, LPN.

She raises her phone and photographs the sheet. The shutter clicks in the quiet kitchen.

Margot flinches. In the hall, the tablet glow goes still.

MARGOT (cont'd)
(barely)
She'll see.

DANA
I know. Let her.

Margot takes the clipboard and goes. Through the kitchen doorway Dana watches her walk down the hall. Priscilla steps out of the dark and holds out her hand. Margot gives her the clipboard.

Priscilla reads Dana's handwriting. Reads it again. Then she tears the page off, gently, along the perforation, and folds it once.

Margot closes her eyes.

Dana opens her notebook and writes fast.

CLOSE ON THE PAGE.

6:47 P.M. OBSERVED: Count 27. Sheet 22. Wrote the real count on the form. Photo taken. Priscilla took the page. ASSESSED: She will replace it. I have the photo.

She sends the photograph to her cloud folder. A progress bar. Done.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - STAFF LOT - NIGHT

From the dark kitchen window, Dana watches Margot's old sedan under the one lamp. The window is cracked an inch for the cooling dishes. Voices carry.

DANIEL (18, thin, garage coveralls) sits in the passenger seat. Margot behind the wheel, both hands on it at ten and two.

DANIEL
Say yes or no. Are they making you do something?

MARGOT
Nobody's making me do anything.

DANIEL
Then why are you shaking?

MARGOT
It's cold.

DANIEL
It's seventy degrees.

Margot says nothing.

DANIEL (cont'd)
I'll go in. I'll tell them about the money myself. You don't have to keep paying for me.

MARGOT
You don't know what that costs.

DANIEL
I know what it costs you.

She turns to him then. Fixes his collar with two fingers, the way a mother does and a man of eighteen allows.

MARGOT
Go home. Lock the door. Eat something that didn't come out of a machine.

He gets out. Bends back to the window.

DANIEL
You don't owe them me.

He walks away. Margot lays her forehead against the wheel.

When she lifts it, she's looking straight at the kitchen window. At the shape of Dana in the dark.

Neither of them moves.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - KITCHEN - PRE-DAWN

TWO DAYS TO THE REVIEW

The house is dark. Dana crosses to the sink for water. On the counter by the stove, under a dish towel, a key on a loop of string.

Margot sits in the dark at the table.

MARGOT
Study key. It's on its hook.

DANA
I don't see a hook.

MARGOT
Then you didn't see me put it there.

Dana doesn't touch it.

DANA
You wrote four ten. It was nearly seven.

MARGOT
I know.

DANA
I was with Eleanor at four ten that afternoon.

MARGOT
I know.

Silence.

DANA
Tell me.

MARGOT
The day of the stroke, Eleanor called me from the bedroom on the house line. She couldn't find her words. I told Priscilla.

DANA
And?

MARGOT
Priscilla said it was a small thing. Don't call anyone. Wait for Adrian.

DANA
How long did you wait?

MARGOT
Three hours.

Dana's chest lifts, falls. She says nothing.

MARGOT (cont'd)
My son took eighteen thousand dollars out of the family safe. Priscilla made the police report disappear. She keeps it in the study. The confession too.

DANA
That's why you didn't call.

MARGOT
That's why I've signed what I've signed.

MARGOT (cont'd)
She wants me to say it to the reviewer on Friday. In person. That I watched you take them.

DANA
What did you tell her?

MARGOT
Yes. That's what I always tell her.

She looks at the key.

MARGOT (cont'd)
Eleven years of yes. Nothing's gotten smaller. It only gets bigger.

MARGOT (cont'd)
She tore your page off in the hall. She had me fax a clean one to your agency.

She slides her fingers off the key.

MARGOT (cont'd)
I told her about the chair.

DANA
I figured.

MARGOT
I didn't know what else to give her. She was standing right there.

DANA
You're giving me this.

MARGOT
That's all I've got.

She looks at the key, then at the wall.

MARGOT (cont'd)
The study camera sits above the door. It doesn't see the records closet. Theresa found that out.

DANA
Found out how?

MARGOT
Don't ask me how.

She looks at the wall.

MARGOT (cont'd)
I left it on its hook.

Dana picks up the key.

MARGOT (cont'd)
I didn't see that.

INT. DOWNTOWN RESTAURANT - PRIVATE ROOM - DAY

A long table of six BOARD MEMBERS in good suits, plates of salad half eaten. Priscilla at the head, a glass of white wine untouched.

Her phone buzzes against the tablecloth. She glances down. A notification: STUDY DOOR - 2:04 PM.

She keeps smiling. She lifts the phone under the table and opens the app. The study feed. Empty. A desk, a window, an empty chair.

PRISCILLA
Forgive me. A household matter.

She stands. Every head turns.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STUDY - DAY

Dana unlocks the door. Closes it behind her. A desk, a filing cabinet, a window onto the empty garden. Above the door frame, a black dome with a red light.

She keeps to the left wall. Under the camera's cone.

She photographs the drawer first. The envelope from behind the portrait, its flap freshly resealed. The ledger. A state registration sheet: HARBOR ACCESS PARTNERS LLC. Registered agent: C. VANCE.

Two clinical notes, side by side, both in Adrian's hand. The first, timestamped 9:41 A.M.: Acute stroke presentation. Activate EMS. The second, timestamped 12:50 P.M.: Patient seen. No acute concern. Transport deferred.

Three hours between them.

A transfer packet dated Friday, two documents stapled. The first: DURABLE FINANCIAL POWER OF ATTORNEY, FOUNDATION ACCOUNTS INCLUDED. The second: HEALTH CARE PROXY AND ADVANCE DIRECTIVE. Both signed Eleanor Whitfield, right-handed, smooth and perfect. At the bottom of the proxy, a blank line: PHYSICIAN ATTESTATION.

A folder, labeled REYES. Inside, a draft statement: Dana Reyes, under personal strain, diverted medication. The count sheet, her signature at the bottom, the time 4:10 p.m.

She understands. Her face tells us she understands.

Outside, tires on gravel.

Dana crosses to the window. A black car at the gate. Priscilla getting out, phone in hand.

Dana turns. The service door on the far wall opens onto the hall where the footsteps are coming from. The only cover is a narrow door to a records closet. She slips inside. Pulls it to.

Darkness. A slit of light. Through it, the study door opens.

Priscilla enters. Her phone is up, the screen glowing. On the display, the study feed. It shows the room. The desk, the cabinet, the window.

She looks from the screen to the room. Nobody.

PRISCILLA
(into phone)
The study door opened at two-oh-four. I'm in the study. Nobody's here.

She waits. Listens.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
(into phone)
Cedar Glen is confirmed for Friday at seven. Once the proxy is attested and the accounts are signed over, the records are mine to restate. She'll be in their care before the reviewer's ten o'clock. She won't be lucid. She'll be present.

She hangs up. She stands very still.

She runs a finger along the desk edge. Looks at the drawer. At the closet.

She takes a step toward the narrow door.

Her phone rings. She looks down. WALTER (BOARD). She lets it ring once more, her eyes on the narrow door.

She answers with a smile Walter can hear.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
(into phone)
Walter. Of course I have time.

She turns. Leaves, still talking, the study door swinging shut behind her.

Dana waits ten seconds. Twenty. She slides out of the closet and out through the service door.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ADRIAN'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Adrian at the desk, the lamp low. Priscilla stands in the doorway with her coat still on.

ADRIAN
Postpone it. Dana's asking questions.

PRISCILLA
If I postpone, the reviewer finds her awake.

ADRIAN
She's your mother.

PRISCILLA
She's the donor base.

Adrian rubs his eyes.

ADRIAN
Priscilla, we can stop. We can pay it back. We can say it was a clerical error.

PRISCILLA
You signed the vendor invoices. You can say whatever you like.

She takes a stapled packet from her bag and lays it in front of him with a pen. The proxy's last page. A line at the bottom: PHYSICIAN ATTESTATION.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
That she understood what she signed. One line. Then Cedar Glen is only a move.

Adrian looks at the signature. Right-handed, smooth. He has watched Eleanor's left hand fail to hold a spoon.

ADRIAN
She can't write with that hand.

PRISCILLA
Then you'll write what she meant.

She leaves the pen on the page. She goes. The door closes behind her.

Adrian sits in the lamplight. The attestation line stays blank. He pushes the pen to the edge of the desk and doesn't touch it again.

He opens a drawer. Inside, a first copy of the packet, a sticky note in his own hand clipped to the corner: ATTEST? Beneath it, a single handwritten page. The original note. 9:41 A.M. Activate EMS.

He reads his own words. Then he lifts the phone from under the page and dials seven digits.

He lets it ring once. Hangs up.

He folds the original note into his breast pocket. He closes the drawer.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STUDY - NIGHT

Priscilla alone, a single lamp. A laptop open on the desk. On the screen, an old news clip: Eleanor at a lectern, silver hair, the Senate seal behind her. The sound is off.

Eleanor's lips move. A public apology, delivered clean and unflinching. Applause rolls across the room in silence.

Priscilla's lips move with her. A half second ahead. She knows every word. A yellowed index card sits beside the keyboard, covered in her own neat handwriting. The same words.

She watches her mother bow her head on screen.

She pulls a legal pad toward her. Uncaps a pen. Writes a signature, right-handed, flowing. Eleanor Whitfield.

She looks at it. Tears the page off. Writes it again. Again. Again.

The pad fills. Eleanor Whitfield. Eleanor Whitfield. Each one a little closer to the real thing.

She stops on the last line. Opens a drawer. Under a stack of folders, a framed photograph, face down. She turns it over.

Priscilla at ten, in a school blazer, standing in front of the portrait that hangs upstairs. Eleanor's hand rests on her shoulder, exactly as it does in the painting. Priscilla is not looking at the camera. She's looking up at her mother.

She sets the photograph face down. Closes the drawer.

On the laptop, the applause ends. Priscilla closes the screen.

THE NIGHT BEFORE

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - DANA'S ROOM - DAY

Dana on the bed, phone to her ear.

AGENCY (V.O.)
Ms. Reyes, the family reports a medication discrepancy from earlier this week.

DANA
There's no discrepancy.

AGENCY (V.O.)
They have a count sheet with your signature. Five tablets short.

Dana closes her eyes.

DANA
I counted twenty-seven. I wrote it on the sheet and I photographed it.

AGENCY (V.O.)
The sheet we have has no notation.

DANA
Then it isn't the sheet I signed.

AGENCY (V.O.)
I can only go by what the family sent.

AGENCY (V.O.) (cont'd)
You're suspended pending review. The family asks that you vacate by morning.

She hangs up. On the pillow, where she didn't leave it, a cashier's check. A cream card paper-clipped to the corner. In Priscilla's hand: Tonight is generous.

Dana looks at the number. Then up at the black dome above the door, red light unblinking.

DANA
(to the camera)
I'm leaving.

She takes the little cardboard square marked DOG off the shelf above the radiator and slips it in her pocket. She sets the check in the middle of the bed. She picks up her bag.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - DAY

Dana kneels at the bed with her bag on her shoulder. Eleanor's eyes are already on it.

DANA
They put me out. I can't stay.

Eleanor looks at the bag. At Dana. Her left hand moves to the card. A finger finds a letter.

DANA (cont'd)
G.

Another.

DANA (cont'd)
O.

Dana shakes her head.

DANA (cont'd)
No.

Eleanor's finger moves again. L. U. C. A.

Dana's face breaks open for a second and closes again.

DANA (cont'd)
You're sending me home to my son.

Eleanor blinks once. Yes.

DANA (cont'd)
I'll come back.

Eleanor's mouth works. Nothing. Then a scrape of sound, the longest she has managed.

ELEANOR
(barely there)
Boy first.

Dana stops breathing.

Eleanor's eyes slide to the card. Then back. Almost annoyed. Don't make a thing of it.

She turns her face to the window. Done.

Dana puts a hand over Eleanor's left. Eleanor doesn't look at her.

Dana gets to her feet. At the foot of the bed, the rail and its beige alarm unit. Beside it, Eleanor's right hand, curled against the blanket.

Dana looks at the hand. It doesn't move.

She leaves.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - FRONT GATE - DUSK

Dana's sedan idles outside the iron gate. Two SECURITY MEN in blazers close the gate behind her and stand with their arms folded.

She looks up at the camera on the gatepost. She holds it a beat longer than she needs to.

She drives.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - STUDY - DUSK

Priscilla at the desk. On her phone, the gate feed. Dana's taillights shrink and vanish.

Priscilla sets the phone face down. Lets out a breath she has been holding for days.

She picks up the other phone.

PRISCILLA
Move it up. Tonight.

INT. TIA CARMEN'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

A small kitchen with mismatched chairs. A quilt over the couch in the next room, where Luca sleeps with the cardboard house in the crook of his arm.

TIA CARMEN (60s, a scarf over her rollers) wipes a counter that is already clean, sees Dana's face, and finds a reason to be in another room.

Rosa sits at the table with the lid of the good pot in her hands. Dana stands in the doorway, her bag still on her shoulder.

ROSA
You're early.

DANA
They put me out.

ROSA
Sit.

Dana sits. Rosa sets a plate in front of her. Dana doesn't touch it.

DANA
At Magnolia. I told you I reported my supervisor.

ROSA
You told me half.

DANA
This is the other half.

Rosa waits.

DANA (cont'd)
I initialed the two a.m. and four a.m. rounds I never did. Mr. Pelley fell and nobody came. He broke his hip. Gail said it was a box and I wanted to go home.

Rosa turns the lid in her hands. A full turn.

ROSA
Why are you here and not there?

DANA
Because they fired me. Because Priscilla knows Luca's name.

ROSA
That's why they put you out. Why are you here?

DANA
Because Luca is here.

ROSA
Good reason. Eat.

Dana picks up the fork. Puts it down.

ROSA (cont'd)
Now tell me what you left there.

Dana looks at the plate.

DANA
Eleanor.

ROSA
Her name is Eleanor.

DANA
She spelled his name today. She sent me home to him.

ROSA
Smart woman.

DANA
They're going to move her. There's a paper that makes Priscilla her voice, for the money and for the care. If she's in that van nobody asks her anything again.

ROSA
Mm.

DANA
If I go back I lose the license. The job. Haddad gets the house. I did the numbers, Mamá.

ROSA
What do the numbers say?

DANA
That I stay right here.

ROSA
Did I ask what the numbers say?

Dana takes out the notebook. Opens it to the day's page. OBSERVED: Patient spelled G-O. L-U-C-A. ASSESSED: She was protecting me.

DANA
You said careful, not scared. Which one is this?

ROSA
I don't know, mija. I wasn't there. You were.

DANA
I need you to tell me.

ROSA
I can't. I can tell you which one you'll tell Luca about.

Dana's phone buzzes on the table. A number she doesn't know. She answers. Nothing. Then Margot, whispering, a hand cupped over the receiver.

MARGOT (V.O.)
They're moving her tonight. The van just went up the drive. Outbuilding line. Service gate behind the garden. The code is the year she testified.

DANA
Margot.

MARGOT (V.O.)
Go.

The line dies. Dana looks at her mother. Rosa doesn't look back.

Rosa gets up. Takes the plate. Scrapes the food into foil. Folds the foil into a neat packet and slides it into Dana's coat pocket.

ROSA
For the car.

Dana stands. In the next room, Luca's eyes are open. He has been watching.

She crosses to the couch and crouches.

LUCA
(whispering)
Where's the dog?

She takes the cardboard DOG square from her coat pocket. Shows him.

DANA
I've got him. I'm holding him for you.

LUCA
Are you coming back?

DANA
I'll be at pickup.

LUCA
Is that a promise?

Dana looks at Rosa. Rosa lets her answer.

DANA
Yes. Pickup.

Luca closes his eyes. Dana kisses his forehead. At the door, Rosa doesn't touch her. She pulls the coat collar straight.

EXT. TIA CARMEN'S HOUSE - DRIVEWAY - NIGHT

Dana in the sedan, phone to her ear.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Ortiz.

DANA
They put me out. They're moving her tonight, not Friday.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
How do you know?

DANA
Margot Bell just called me from inside the house.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Will she say that to a judge?

DANA
In about a year.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
I'm sending a patrol and paramedics. Twenty minutes. I'll stage them at the foot of the hill. You stay at the gate.

DANA
Twenty minutes is a van and a signature.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Ms. Reyes. I can't send you through a door.

DANA
I know.

ORTIZ (V.O.)
Stay out of the house.

Dana says nothing. She hangs up. Starts the car.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - GARDEN WALL - NIGHT

Dana parks on the verge and walks the length of the old stone wall in the dark. Through the gate bars, far up the drive, a white private transport van sits at the front steps with its back doors open.

A keypad on the service gate. A camera on the wall above it. She hugs the shadow of the hedge, under the camera's cone, the way she did in the study.

She types four digits. A green light. The latch gives.

She slips through and shuts it behind her without a sound.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - SERVICE HALLWAY - NIGHT

Dana enters in the dark. The kitchen. The narrow hall. Footsteps overhead.

She takes the back stairs two at a time and stops at the top. Through a crack in Eleanor's door, light.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT

Eleanor sits against the pillows, awake. Adrian stands at the bedside with a loaded syringe at his side. Priscilla by the window. In the doorway, two TRANSPORT ATTENDANTS in navy polos, a folded gurney between them.

Dana enters. Closes the door behind her.

PRISCILLA
You're trespassing.

DANA
I'm the nurse in this room.

She crosses to the bed. Takes Eleanor's left hand. Eleanor squeezes once.

ATTENDANT ONE
Ma'am, we have a transfer authorization.

He holds out a sheet. Dana takes it. Reads. At the bottom, a flowing signature. Eleanor Whitfield, right-handed, smooth.

DANA
Look at her hand.

The Attendants look. Eleanor's right hand, curled against her thigh.

DANA (cont'd)
She has no functional grip in that hand. She could not have signed this.

ATTENDANT TWO
(to Adrian)
Doctor?

Adrian doesn't answer. His thumb is on the plunger.

PRISCILLA
Dr. Vance has confirmed the transfer.

ATTENDANT ONE
I need to hear that from him. Or I need dispatch to verify the order.

He takes out his phone. No bars. Priscilla steps toward him.

PRISCILLA
The system's down for an update. The signal in the drive is better.

ATTENDANT ONE
(to his partner)
Come on.

They go. Priscilla follows, one hand already reaching for the first man's elbow.

PRISCILLA
Let me show you where it is.

Their voices go down the stairs. The room is Dana, Adrian, Eleanor and a loaded syringe.

DANA
Show me the order for the syringe.

He looks at the nightstand. A handwritten sheet lies under the lamp. He lifts it. Holds it out. Dana reads. The order is in Priscilla's neat hand. Under it, a scrawl that might be a doctor's.

DANA (cont'd)
That's not your handwriting.

ADRIAN
No.

He caps the syringe and slides it into his jacket pocket.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
It doesn't stay in this room. At nine forty-one that morning I wrote an order for EMS. She asked me to hold it until the review was safe. I held it three hours.

He takes a folded page from his breast pocket. The original note. He doesn't hand it over. He holds it up.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
I'm taking this downstairs.

DANA
She'll take it from you.

ADRIAN
Then she'll have to do it in front of them.

He goes. The door swings shut behind him.

Dana drags the desk chair under the handle. Pulls the nightstand against the door.

She kneels at the bed.

DANA
I'm going to ask you one question. Squeeze once for yes.

Eleanor looks at her.

DANA (cont'd)
Do you want to leave this house?

Eleanor's hand closes on hers. Once. Hard.

DANA (cont'd)
That's all I needed.

EXT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - FRONT STEPS - NIGHT

The transport van, back doors open. Attendant One has his phone to his ear, a bar of signal at last. Priscilla beside him, smiling, one hand on his sleeve.

The front door opens. Adrian comes out holding a folded page in front of him like a ticket.

ADRIAN
Do not move her.

Priscilla's smile stays on. Her hand tightens on the sleeve.

ATTENDANT ONE
Sir?

ADRIAN
I'm Dr. Adrian Vance. I do not authorize this transfer. The signature on your sheet is forged. This is my original note from the morning of her stroke. I'm going to give it to the first police officer who gets here.

Priscilla looks at the page. At her husband.

PRISCILLA
Adrian.

ATTENDANT ONE
(into phone)
Dispatch, I'm going to need to put a hold on this.

Priscilla lets go of his sleeve. At the foot of the steps, RAY, the gate guard, has watched all of it. She crosses to him, voice low and warm.

PRISCILLA
Ray. A dismissed employee has barricaded herself in with my mother. She has her medication. She isn't well.

RAY
Ma'am?

PRISCILLA
I need that door open before the police get here and a frightened woman makes this worse.

She walks into the house. Ray looks at Adrian on the steps. At the van. Follows.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - BASEMENT - NIGHT

Priscilla walks down the stairs to a utility closet, Ray at her shoulder. A gray panel, rows of breakers. She doesn't hesitate.

RAY
Ma'am. The lights?

PRISCILLA
The cameras are recording that woman with my mother. I won't have her filmed like that.

She throws the main.

EXT. WHITFIELD ESTATE - NIGHT

The house goes dark window by window, floor by floor. A single porch light dies last.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - NIGHT

Black. Dana's phone lights up, a small bright cone. Eleanor's face in it, eyes wide.

The wall-mounted call bell is dead. The monitor is dead. Out in the hall, the camera's red light is dead.

The handle turns from the outside. The door shudders against the chair and the nightstand.

PRISCILLA (O.S.)
Mother.

Eleanor's eyes go to the door.

PRISCILLA (O.S.) (cont'd)
I'm going to come in and sit with you. I'm going to explain.

The door shudders again.

PRISCILLA (O.S.) (cont'd)
You got to be the brave one. I got to be the one who answered the phone.

Eleanor's lips part.

ELEANOR
(thin, rough)
I should have seen you.

A silence on the other side of the door.

ELEANOR (cont'd)
Not yours.

Nothing from Priscilla. Then a shoulder hits the door. And again, heavier. The chair cracks. The nightstand scrapes back six inches.

A flashlight beam cuts through the gap. RAY, the gate guard, shoving. Behind him, Priscilla, white. And somewhere behind her, Adrian's voice, ragged.

ADRIAN (O.S.)
Priscilla. Stop.

Ray pushes in. Priscilla comes after him and reaches for Dana.

Dana steps between her and the bed.

DANA
Eleanor. The button.

Eleanor's left hand moves. Not fast enough. She can't reach.

Priscilla's hand closes on Dana's shoulder.

In the phone's pale light, Eleanor's right hand, locked against the rail for weeks, shakes. The thumb lifts a quarter inch. The way it lifted for the silver brush.

It finds the red button. It presses.

An alarm explodes through the dark house. Priscilla recoils, hands over her ears. Dana's phone light jerks across the ceiling.

Eleanor keeps her thumb down. Her whole arm trembles with it.

Priscilla recoils. Then she sees where the sound is coming from. She lunges for the alarm unit on the rail, nails scrabbling at its clip.

Dana catches her wrist and pins it against the rail. Priscilla's other hand claws for Eleanor's thumb.

PRISCILLA
Ray! Ray, take it off her!

Ray in the doorway, his flashlight on the bed. In the beam: Eleanor's face, wet, her jaw clenched. Her thumb white on the red button. Priscilla's fingers on her hand.

RAY
Ma'am.

PRISCILLA
Take it off her!

RAY
She's pressing it herself.

Priscilla stops. Breathing hard. Ray crosses the room and takes her wrist from the rail. He doesn't let go.

Boots on the stairs, following the sound. Voices. Dana doesn't loosen her grip on anything.

INT. WHITFIELD HOUSE - ELEANOR'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Boots in the hall. Two PARAMEDICS enter, followed by two uniformed OFFICERS with flashlights. The alarm still wails.

PARAMEDIC ONE
Ma'am. We're here for Eleanor Whitfield. Detective Ortiz called it in.

Ray, still holding Priscilla's wrist, lets go of it and steps back with his hands visible. Behind the officers, Adrian, holding a folded page out to the nearest OFFICER.

ADRIAN
Original clinical note. Nine forty-one. The morning of her stroke.

The Officer takes it. Adrian empties his jacket pocket into the second Officer's gloved hand. The capped syringe.

ADRIAN (cont'd)
That was meant for her.

Eleanor's thumb is still pinned to the red button.

PARAMEDIC ONE
Mrs. Whitfield. We're going to move you now.

She doesn't let go.

PARAMEDIC TWO
(to Dana)
Has she been like this long?

DANA
She has no grip in that hand. That's her thumb.

PARAMEDIC ONE
Ma'am. You're safe.

Her thumb doesn't move. Her eyes are on Dana.

DANA
(softly)
Eleanor.

Eleanor's thumb lifts. The alarm dies. The silence is enormous. Then the hand drops to the blanket.

PARAMEDIC ONE
Does she want her family with her?

Eleanor looks past Dana. At the doorway, where Priscilla stands with two officers at her shoulders.

ELEANOR
No.

The paramedics lift her onto the stretcher. Dana walks beside it. Eleanor's left hand holds Dana's wrist all the way down the stairs.

Priscilla stays where she is. Her hand is on the doorframe. She doesn't follow.

INT. GRADY MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - ER BAY - NIGHT

Eleanor asleep under monitors. Dana in a plastic chair. DETECTIVE LENA ORTIZ (40s, plain clothes, badge on her belt) drops a folder on the tray table.

ORTIZ
Warrant on the study went out at one. The originals were in the drawer.
(MORE)

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Mrs. Whitfield's margin notes, in her hand, dated nine days before the stroke. Harbor Access has a registered agent named Vance. The bank records will tell us who the money went back to.

DANA
And the three hours?

Ortiz slides out two pages. The 911 log for the Whitfield address, blank for the morning of the stroke. And a clinical note in Adrian's hand. 9:41 A.M.

ORTIZ
No call. A note that says call. A second note, three hours later, that says don't. Any one of those is a story. Together they're a timeline.

Dana looks at Eleanor. At the monitors.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
They also gave your agency a count sheet. Five short, no notation.

She sets down a printed photograph. The sheet, Dana's handwriting under the typed line. COUNTED 27 AT 6:47 P.M. Her signature. A timestamp in the corner.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Your cloud folder. The page they sent isn't this one. Ms. Bell says Mrs. Whitfield-Vance tore it off in the hall.

DANA
I should have refused to put my name on anything.

ORTIZ
You wrote the truth under your own name. That's what held.

She taps the notebook on the tray table.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Observed, then assessed. Every entry.

DANA
They picked me because of the first one.

ORTIZ
They were wrong about what you'd do with it.

She starts for the door. Stops.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
The gatehouse log has you at the gate at two forty-one with your phone up. It matches your file times.

DANA
They keep good records.

ORTIZ
So do you.

Ortiz taps the folder on her way out.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Statement at six. Bring a lawyer.

INT. GRADY MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Priscilla in a visitor's chair, hands in her lap, no coat. Two officers at a polite distance.

Through the glass, Eleanor's room. The lights dimmed.

PRISCILLA
Mother.

Eleanor, awake, doesn't turn her head.

PRISCILLA (cont'd)
I loved you first.

A long beat.

ELEANOR
Then love me second.

An OFFICER touches Priscilla's elbow. She stands. She does not look back.

INT. GRADY MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - HALLWAY - LATER

Margot, in her good coat, stands at the end of the hall holding her purse in both hands. Dana goes to her.

MARGOT
I gave my statement. They said I'll be charged.

DANA
Probably.

MARGOT
I know.

She opens her purse. Takes out a mechanical pencil. Holds it out to Dana.

MARGOT (cont'd)
First week after the stroke, she asked me for a pencil. I said no.

Dana doesn't take it.

DANA
Give it to her yourself.

Margot looks at the door. Then goes in.

Through the glass, Dana watches Margot set the pencil on the tray. Eleanor looks at it. At Margot. Her left hand comes up and lies on Margot's wrist.

INT. GRADY MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - ELEANOR'S ROOM - MORNING

THREE DAYS LATER

Daylight. Eleanor propped against clean pillows, her hair brushed by someone kind. Her right hand lies on the blanket, less clenched than before, the thumb free. Dana stands at the window. Ortiz sits in the visitor chair with a small recorder on her knee.

In the corner, KEZIA ADAMS, cardigan, reading glasses on a beaded chain, a tablet on her knee.

ORTIZ
Ms. Adams, your card was in Ms. Reyes's notebook. You're here as an independent clinician.

ADAMS
I've been waiting for that call. I kept the recording of our video call, timestamped nine fourteen. And my copy of the letter Dr. Vance's office says it never received.

ORTIZ
Mrs. Whitfield, I'll ask. You answer however you can. Nobody's rushing.

Eleanor looks at Dana. Dana nods.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Did you sign a transfer packet dated this Friday?

ELEANOR
No.

ORTIZ
Did you hide papers behind the portrait?

Eleanor nods.

ORTIZ (cont'd)
Why there?

ELEANOR
(thin, slow)
Everyone looks at it. Nobody looks behind it.

Ortiz almost smiles. Writes.

ORTIZ
The day of your stroke. What do you remember?

Eleanor's jaw works. She looks at the ceiling.

ELEANOR
Words gone. I called Margot.

ORTIZ
And?

ELEANOR
Three hours.

ORTIZ
Do you know why they waited?

ELEANOR
I found the vendor.

A beat. Her eyes find Dana.

ELEANOR (cont'd)
And I'd have been the one who told.

ORTIZ
Hallam Pharma. We've asked for the original disclosure records. They'll name you, Mrs. Whitfield.

ELEANOR
Good.

ORTIZ
That's not what most people say.

ELEANOR
People took the pills while I waited. Name me.

Ortiz sets a release form on a clipboard across the tray. She holds out the pencil Margot gave Eleanor.

Eleanor takes it in her left hand. Writes. The letters are huge, shaky, a child's. It takes a full minute. Nobody speaks.

Ortiz takes the clipboard. Lays the forged transfer letter beside it. A smooth, flowing signature. Next to it, a shaking one.

ORTIZ
That's the real one.

Eleanor looks at the two names. At her right hand, thumb free, fingers still curled.

ELEANOR
(almost a smile)
Terrible handwriting.

DANA
I've seen worse.

INT. ROSA'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

The same kitchen. The same counter. Unopened envelopes, but only two now, and one is open. A cake on the table, from the corner bakery.

Rosa cuts three slices. Luca holds up the cardboard house. A fifth room, a back door, a tiny square of green marker. Written in block letters: CASA.

LUCA
It has a yard now.

DANA
So I see.

LUCA
For the dog.

Dana takes the little DOG square from her coat pocket. Sets it on the table. Luca slides it into the new back door of the house. It fits.

Dana looks at her mother. Rosa shrugs.

DANA
We'll talk about it.

LUCA
You always say that.

DANA
You always remember.

Rosa slides a slice to Dana.

ROSA
New job?

DANA
Team placement. Day shift. A nurse manager who reads the charts. Renee vouched for me.

ROSA
And the board?

DANA
Hasn't ruled. Magnolia's complaint is still open.

ROSA
But.

DANA
But they hired me anyway.

ROSA
School pickup?

DANA
Every day.

ROSA
Good.

Dana eats. Rosa watches her.

ROSA (cont'd)
You look different.

DANA
Tired?

ROSA
No.

Rosa pushes the cake closer.

ROSA (cont'd)
Eat.

EXT. REHABILITATION GARDEN - DAY

SIX WEEKS LATER

Stone benches. A trimmed hedge. The kind of quiet an insurance company pays for.

Eleanor sits in a wheelchair with a blanket over her knees. Beside her, Dana. Luca on the bench holding the cardboard house, turning it in the light.

Eleanor's right hand rests on the arm of the chair. It isn't strong. It's moving.

LUCA
Did you build any of it?

ELEANOR
(thin)
Not yet.

LUCA
We'll build you a room. With a window.

ELEANOR
So I can see the dog.

LUCA
So you can see the dog.

Eleanor almost smiles. Beside her on the bench, a small recorder and a stack of typed pages.

Dana looks at the recorder.

DANA
Ready?

Eleanor presses record.

ELEANOR
The first time I could have told the truth, I didn't.

She looks at Dana. Then at Luca. Then at the hedge.

Dana takes Luca's hand. Luca leans into her side.

Eleanor lets the recorder run. A breeze moves through the hedge.

On the bench, Dana moves the recorder an inch, so it sits where Eleanor's left hand doesn't have to reach.

The recorder keeps running.

FADE OUT.

THE END